

Module 07: Communication — Speaking From the Body, Hearing With the Body

Learning Objectives

1. Explain how **embodied communication** operates through somatic channels — tone of voice, facial expression, gesture, posture — that transmit felt sense between organisms.
2. Describe the role of **interoceptive resonance** and **mirror mechanisms** in enabling one body to feel what another body feels.
3. Analyze Gendlin's concept of **carrying forward** — how articulating the felt sense in language transforms and deepens somatic experience.
4. Recognize that communication in the felt sense framework is fundamentally a process of **generative model alignment** between embodied agents.

Introduction

You are sitting with a friend who is grieving. She has not spoken yet, but your body already knows. There is a heaviness in the room, a slowing of your own breath, a subtle ache in your chest that was not there before you sat down. Her grief has crossed the space between you and registered in your body as a felt sense. This is embodied communication at its most fundamental: not the exchange of propositions but the transmission of somatic states between living systems.

Long before language evolved, organisms communicated through the body — through posture, movement, vocalization, and the direct physiological influence of one organism on another. Even now, with all the sophistication of language, the deepest layers of human communication remain somatic. The tone of voice that contradicts the words, the facial micro-expression that reveals the hidden emotion, the postural shift that signals withdrawal — these bodily signals carry more communicative weight than their verbal counterparts. Active inference reveals why: embodied communication is the process by which generative models synchronize, reducing the free energy of mutual prediction.

Key Concepts

1. Interoceptive Resonance and Empathy

When you witness another person's pain, your own body responds: your muscles tense, your heart rate shifts, your facial expression mirrors theirs. This is **interoceptive resonance** — the phenomenon by which one organism's bodily states induce corresponding states in another. Vittorio Gallese has argued that this resonance, mediated by mirror neuron systems, provides the somatic foundation of empathy. In active inference, resonance occurs because your generative model predicts not only your own interoceptive states but the states of others: when you observe a pained expression, your model generates the interoceptive prediction that would accompany your own pain, producing a felt sense of the other's experience.

2. Vocal Prosody as Somatic Signal

The semantic content of speech carries only a fraction of its communicative meaning. **Prosody** — the rhythm, pitch, volume, and tonal quality of the voice — communicates directly to the listener's body. Stephen Porges's polyvagal theory emphasizes that specific prosodic features (the "music" of speech) engage the social engagement system, signaling safety or threat through direct vagal pathways. A calm, melodic voice activates the ventral vagal complex, producing a felt sense of safety. A sharp, staccato voice activates sympathetic arousal, producing a felt sense of alarm. In active inference, vocal prosody modulates the precision of the listener's interoceptive predictions — calming voices lower the precision on threat-related prediction errors, while alarming voices amplify them.

3. Gendlin's Carrying Forward: Language as Felt Sense Completion

Eugene Gendlin observed that when we find the right words for a felt sense, something shifts in the body — a release, an opening, a sense of "yes, that's it." He called this **carrying forward**: language does not merely label pre-existing feelings but actively transforms and completes them. The felt sense is implicit and unfinished; language carries it forward into explicit, differentiated form. In active inference, this corresponds to a reduction in interoceptive free energy: the verbal formulation provides a higher-level prediction that

explains and organizes the previously vague interoceptive signals, producing a "felt shift" as the model achieves a better fit.

4. Somatic Attunement in Therapeutic and Relational Contexts

Daniel Stern's concept of **affect attunement** describes the process by which caregivers match not the specific behavior of an infant but its felt quality — its intensity, timing, and contour. When a baby reaches excitedly for a toy and the mother responds with a matching vocal crescendo, she is communicating: "I feel what you feel." This cross-modal matching of felt sense is the foundation of secure attachment and emotional regulation. In active inference, attunement is generative model alignment: two organisms' models converge on a shared representation of the current affective state, minimizing the mutual prediction error between them.

5. The Limits of Language and the Primacy of Somatic Communication

Not everything that can be felt can be said. The felt sense frequently exceeds linguistic articulation — there are dimensions of somatic experience for which no adequate words exist. This is not a failure of language but a structural feature of embodied communication: the body's generative model operates in a higher-dimensional space than language can capture. Silence, touch, shared breathing, and co-present stillness may communicate more of the felt sense than any verbal formulation. In therapeutic and contemplative contexts, the ability to sit with the incommunicable — to hold the felt sense without forcing it into words — is a communicative skill of the highest order.

Active Inference Connection

Communication in the felt sense framework is the process by which generative models influence and align with each other across the boundary of individual Markov blankets. When I speak from my felt sense and you receive my words in your body, my generative model's predictions are shaping yours — and yours, through your responses, shape mine in return. Free energy is minimized jointly: both organisms' models converge toward a shared understanding

of the current situation. This mutual, embodied inference is the deepest form of communication — not the transfer of information but the co-creation of shared felt meaning.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Empathic Listening as Somatic Resonance:** In your next conversation, bring attention to your own body while listening. Notice how the other person's words, tone, and posture register as felt sensations in your own body — a tightening, a warmth, a heaviness, an opening. These somatic responses are your generative model's empathic predictions, offering you information about the speaker's felt state that may exceed what their words explicitly convey.
- **Case Study — Focusing Partnerships and Relational Carrying Forward:** In Gendlin's Focusing practice, a listener accompanies a focuser without interpreting, advising, or analyzing — simply reflecting back the felt sense as the focuser articulates it. This relational container amplifies the focuser's interoceptive precision: the presence of an attuned other creates conditions of safety that allow the generative model to relax its defensive priors and attend more openly to the felt sense. The relational field itself becomes a medium of inference, with both participants' bodies contributing to the shared process of meaning-making.

Cross-References

- **Module 06 (Learning):** Communicating felt experience reinforces interoceptive discrimination — articulation refines what we can feel.
- **Module 08 (Planning):** Communicating intentions and felt assessments enables collaborative planning between embodied agents.
- **Unit 02 (Living Presence):** Present-moment awareness is the foundation of genuine empathic communication.

Summary

Communication in the felt sense framework transcends the exchange of propositions. It is the somatic process by which one body's felt states influence and resonate with another's —

through vocal prosody, facial expression, gestural mirroring, and the direct physiological impact of shared presence. Gendlin's carrying forward reveals that language, at its best, does not merely label feelings but transforms them. Active inference frames communication as mutual generative model alignment: two embodied agents reducing their joint free energy through the co-creation of shared felt meaning. The deepest communication does not inform the mind; it moves the body.